Haligric Research Integration Series

The Sun's Children of the Reindeer Road

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

The Sacred Traditions of the Sámi, Indigenous Peoples of Sápmi (Arctic Scandinavia)

Across the far north of Norway, Sweden, Finland, and Russia lies Sápmi, homeland of Europe's only formally recognized Indigenous people — reindeer herders whose drum maps the entire cosmos on a single painted hide.

Here the sun is a mother, thunder is a patron of the herds, and a song called a joik does not describe a person or a mountain but becomes it, if only for the length of the singing.

This is a tradition Christian missionaries spent three centuries trying to silence — burning drums, banning joik outright in schoolrooms into the 1950s — and one that a national high court, in 2021, found a modern government had violated all over again.

It is still, today, an active fight over the same frozen ground the noaidi once mapped with a drumstick.

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Introduction — The Sun's Children of the Reindeer Road

The Sámi are the Indigenous people of Sápmi, a homeland spanning the northern regions of Norway, Sweden, Finland, and Russia's Kola Peninsula, and are formally recognized as the only Indigenous people within the European Union's territory. Traditional Sámi life centers on reindeer herding, along with fishing, hunting, and gathering, in a subarctic environment whose extreme seasonal light cycle — near-constant summer daylight and deep winter darkness — shapes both practical life and religious symbolism.

Sámi traditional religion, though substantially disrupted by centuries of Christian missionization described below, shares clear structural affinities with other circumpolar and Arctic Indigenous traditions — including the Inuit religion covered elsewhere in this series — centered on shamanic practice, a tiered cosmos, and an intimate, taboo-governed relationship with the land and the reindeer herds that sustain it.

Origins and the Three-Tiered Cosmos

Sámi cosmology organizes the universe into three interconnected realms: an upper world governed by Radien-attje, a middle world — the realm of ordinary human and animal life — associated with Horagalles, and a lower underworld ruled by Jábmiidáhkká, keeper of the dead. This tiered structure directly shapes the noaidi's ritual practice, since the shaman's central task is spiritual travel between these levels rather than communication confined to a single plane.

Beaivi (also Pejvve), the sun, holds central cosmological importance as a solar deity understood in some traditions as the mythological mother of the Sámi people, reflecting the sun's outsized practical and psychological importance in a homeland defined by extreme seasonal daylight variation. Horagalles, the thunder god and patron of both the Sámi people and their reindeer pastures, shows clear historical syncretism with Norse Thor, a product of centuries of contact with Scandinavian neighbors.

Cosmology and the Spirit World

A cluster of female deities known collectively as the Akka goddesses governs household, birth, and protective domains: Máttaráhkká (Madderakka) is the primordial mother figure; her daughters include Sáráhkká, who presides over childbirth itself and is closely associated with the hearth doorway; Uksáhkká, guardian of the household threshold; and Juksáhkká, protector specifically of male children. This structure of a senior mother goddess and her differentiated daughters closely parallels household and birth-protection deity clusters found in numerous other circumpolar and Northern European traditions.

Sacred natural sites called sieidi — distinctively shaped rocks, cliffs, or other landscape features — served, and in some communities continue to serve, as offering places where hunters, herders, and fishers left gifts (traditionally reindeer antlers, bones, or other valued items) in exchange for successful hunting, herding, or fishing, embedding Sámi religious practice directly and specifically in the physical landscape of Sápmi rather than in constructed temples or shrines.

The Noaidi and the Sacred Drum

The noaidi, the Sámi shamanic specialist, mediated between the human community and the three-tiered spirit world, using a distinctive shamanic drum (goavddis) as the central tool of practice: a wooden frame or hollowed body covered with painted reindeer hide bearing a cosmological diagram, typically with the sun placed at the center surrounded by depictions of gods, animals, and spirit-guides relevant to the drum owner's specific practice and lineage.

The noaidi used the drum in two principal ways: moving a small pointer or indicator across the painted hide's surface as a divinatory technique for answering specific questions, and sustained rhythmic drumming to induce trance, enabling the noaidi's free soul to travel through the cosmic realms — to retrieve lost souls, diagnose illness, or negotiate with the spirits governing the hunt or the herd — in a practice structurally very similar to the angakkuq's spirit journeys described in this series' Arctic/Inuit volume, despite the substantial geographic distance and lack of direct contact between the two traditions.

Joik — Singing a Person or Place into Being

Joik (also spelled yoik) is the traditional Sámi vocal form, and it operates on a fundamentally different logic than song in most other traditions: a joik does not describe its subject but is understood to evoke or actually embody it, whether the subject is a specific person, an animal, or a landscape feature — Sámi tradition holds that one does not joik about a person but joiks the person themselves. Traditional joiks are performed a cappella, typically in a pentatonic tonal framework, frequently with minimal or no fixed lyrics, and with substantial room for individual improvisation, making each performance of a given joik somewhat distinct even when it is understood to represent the same subject across many performances and many years.

Joik carried direct shamanistic significance historically, with some joiks used specifically to accompany noaidi ritual practice and to imitate the sounds of the natural and spirit world during ceremony, a connection that made the practice a particular target of Christian missionary suppression from the seventeenth century onward.

Key Figures and Institutions

The Sámi Parliaments established in Norway (1989), Sweden (1993), and Finland (1996) represent the modern institutional expression of Sámi self-determination, each functioning as an elected representative body with varying degrees of legislative and cultural authority over Sámi affairs within its respective national government, following a twentieth-century political shift from explicit state assimilation policy toward formal, if still incomplete, recognition of Sámi rights.

Contemporary joik artists — including Mari Boine, Wimme Saari, and Jon Henrik Fjällgren — have carried the tradition into international popular music, blending traditional joiking with jazz, rock, and electronic genres, and joik reached an unprecedented global audience through its incorporation into Disney's Frozen franchise and multiple Eurovision Song Contest performances, both cited as significant milestones in mainstream cultural recognition of a previously suppressed tradition.

Self-Care, Wellness, and Daily Practice

Reindeer herding itself functions as a deeply embedded practice of physical, seasonal, and spiritual discipline, with the herd's movements dictating the yearly calendar and requiring an intimate, continuously renewed knowledge of weather, snow condition, and terrain that Sámi herders describe in terms of relationship and responsibility rather than simple resource management.

Joik, alongside its ceremonial and artistic functions, continues to serve a genuine wellness and identity-affirming role within Sámi communities today, particularly amid the broader twentieth-century experience of forced assimilation policy (including Norway's historical 'Norwegianization' school system, which, alongside banning joik outright in some Sámi-area schools into the 1950s, sought to suppress Sámi language and dress as well); contemporary joik revival and teaching programs are frequently framed explicitly in terms of cultural and psychological healing for a population that experienced sustained, state-directed suppression of language and religious practice within living memory.

Legacy and Influence

The Sámi Parliament model has been referenced internationally as an example of formal Indigenous political representation achieved within an existing state structure rather than through separate statehood, and Sámi joik's mainstream cultural breakthrough via Frozen and Eurovision has been widely credited with substantially raising international public awareness of Sámi culture beyond Scandinavian and Arctic studies specialist circles.

As one of very few Indigenous traditions to survive centuries of sustained assimilation pressure from wealthy, stable, developed states (rather than through frontier conflict or disease-driven demographic collapse), the Sámi experience is frequently studied comparatively alongside other Arctic Indigenous peoples' revitalization movements, including the Inuit cultural revival described elsewhere in this series.

Christian Suppression and the Fosen Case — Controversies and Fairness

From the seventeenth century onward, Scandinavian church and state authorities pursued sustained campaigns against Sámi traditional religion, including the confiscation and burning of noaidi drums (a large majority of which were destroyed, with most surviving examples now held in museum collections rather than in Sámi communities), and later, twentieth-century Norwegianization education policy explicitly banned joik in many Sámi-area schools into the 1950s; as recently as 2014, a Norwegian parish council publicly debated instituting a total ban on joik performance in church contexts, illustrating the tradition's still-contested status even in the present day.

In October 2021, Norway's Supreme Court unanimously ruled that licenses granted for the Fosen wind farm complex — comprising the Storheia, Roan, and Fosen Vind turbine installations, among Europe's largest onshore wind developments — violated Article 27 of the International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights by destroying critical winter reindeer grazing land essential to South Sámi herders' ability to practice their culture, since the turbines' noise and visual presence frighten reindeer away from viable pasture. Despite the licenses being declared unlawful, the turbines continued operating for more than two years with no government remedy, prompting sustained protests in Oslo — including demonstrations joined by climate activist Greta Thunberg in February 2023 — before Norway and Sámi representatives reached a negotiated settlement in March 2024 allowing the wind farm to continue operating in exchange for new winter grazing areas, dedicated local energy allocation, and cultural support funding; the settlement remains contested by some Sámi herders as an inadequate remedy for what the Supreme Court itself had already found to be an unlawful violation of Indigenous cultural rights.

Closing

The drums that survived confiscation and burning are mostly in museums now, but the songs were harder to take: joik outlived the ban, and a Sámi artist has since sung it into a Disney soundtrack and onto the Eurovision stage.

The reindeer are still the herders' clock and calendar, and the turbines that came for their winter pasture are, as of 2024, subject to a negotiated settlement that neither side calls final.

Grand rising to the sun's children of the reindeer road — Sápmi keeps its own time, drum-marked, still.